Hamiltonian Thresholds for Planar Recolouring Graphs

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Abstract

Let $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ be the graph of all proper colourings of a finite graph G with a labelled palette $[k]$, with one-vertex recolourings as edges. We collect sharp Hamiltonian and Hamilton-connected thresholds for planar graph classes. A d-degenerate graph has a Hamilton-connected and vertex-pancyclic recolouring graph for every $k \geq d+3$. The resulting Hamilton-connected thresholds are 7 for all planar graphs, 5 for triangle-free planar graphs (and hence for bipartite planar graphs), 4 for planar graphs of girth at least six, and 4 for nonempty forests. We give the exact Hamiltonian thresholds 4 for planar girth-five graphs with at most seven distinct 5-cycles, for maximum degree at most three. For these girth-five classes, four-colour Hamilton-connectedness remains open. The general planar girth-five four-colour problem remains open: the current bounds are $4 \leq h \leq 5$ and $4 \leq \mathrm{hc} \leq 5$.

1 Introduction

All graphs in this paper are finite and simple; they may be disconnected. A forest is assigned infinite girth. Colours are labelled, and a proper colouring need not use every colour. All graph classes in the threshold definitions below consist of nonempty graphs. If G is a graph, then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ has as vertices the proper maps $\sigma : V(G) \to [k]$, and two colourings are adjacent when they differ on exactly one vertex of G.

A graph is Hamiltonian if it has a spanning cycle, Hamilton-connected if every two distinct vertices are joined by a spanning path, and vertex-pancyclic if every vertex lies on a cycle of every length between three and the order of the graph. For a class $\mathcal{C}$ of nonempty graphs define

$$h(\mathcal{C}) = \min\{q : \mathcal{R}_k(G) \text{ is Hamiltonian for all } G \in \mathcal{C},\ k \geq q\},$$

$$\mathrm{hc}(\mathcal{C}) = \min\{q : \mathcal{R}_k(G) \text{ is Hamilton-connected for all } G \in \mathcal{C},\ k \geq q\},$$

whenever the displayed set is nonempty. The word threshold always has this uniform meaning; no monotonicity in k is assumed.

The principal conclusions are summarized in the threshold table near the end of this version. A range such as $4 \leq \mathrm{hc} \leq 5$ records a proved four-colour lower bound and a proved five-colour upper bound, with the four-colour Hamilton-connected statement unresolved.

The four-colour recolouring graph of every planar graph of girth at least five is connected by Bartier et al. [5]. Earlier recolouring and Gray-code work gives useful connectivity context [1, 2], but the Hamilton-connected strengthening used here is separate. Connectivity, a Hamilton cycle in a restricted fibre, and a finite state computation do not imply a Hamilton cycle of the complete recolouring graph.

2 The degenerate theorem

We begin with the general result that supplies all large-palette statements.

Lemma 2.1 (Cyclic list selection)**.** *Let $m \geq 3$ and let $L_1, \ldots, L_m$ be finite sets of size at least two. Unless m is odd and all L_i are the same two-element set, there are $x_i \in L_i$ with $x_i \neq x_{i+1}$ cyclically.*

Proof. If some L_i has at least three elements, choose successively along the path obtained by deleting that position, then choose the remaining element to avoid both end values. If all sets are binary and two consecutive sets differ, start with a value in their symmetric difference and continue greedily. If all are the same binary set, alternation is possible exactly when m is even. □ □

Lemma 2.2 (One-vertex lift)**.** *Let $H = G - v \neq \varnothing$ and suppose $k \geq d_G(v) + 3$. If $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ has a Hamilton cycle, then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ has a Hamilton cycle.*

Proof. Write a Hamilton cycle of $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ as $f_1, \ldots, f_m, f_1$ and put $L_i = [k] \setminus f_i(N_G(v))$. Then $|L_i| \geq 3$ and $|L_i \cap L_{i+1}| \geq 2$. Lemma 2.1 gives cyclic choices $x_i \in L_i \cap L_{i+1}$ with consecutive values distinct. The extensions above f_i form a clique on L_i; traverse that clique by a Hamilton path from x_{i-1} to x_i, and use the edge with v fixed at x_i to cross to the next fibre. The exceptional all-identical binary case is impossible because every proper colouring of H occurs on the base cycle and a global colour permutation changes a neighbour of v to either binary colour. The fibre paths therefore concatenate to a spanning cycle. □ □

Lemma 2.3 (Bridge colours)**.** *Let $t \geq 1$, and let $S_0, \ldots, S_{t-1}$ be finite sets of colours such that $|S_i| \geq 2$ for every i. Suppose that $|S_j| \geq 3$ for some $j \in \{0, \ldots, t-1\}$. For any colours a and b, there exist colours $x_i \in S_i$ satisfying*

$$x_0 \neq a, \qquad x_i \neq x_{i-1} \quad (1 \leq i \leq t-1), \qquad x_{t-1} \neq b.$$

Proof. Set $x_{-1} = a$ and $x_t = b$. Choose $x_0, \ldots, x_{j-1}$ in this order, each time avoiding the preceding colour. Then choose $x_{t-1}, \ldots, x_{j+1}$ in this order, each time avoiding the following colour. Each of these choices excludes at most one colour from a list of size at least two. Finally choose

$$x_j \in S_j \setminus \{x_{j-1}, x_{j+1}\}.$$

At most two colours are excluded, so this choice is possible. The boundary assignments $x_{-1} = a$ and $x_t = b$ also cover $j = 0$, $j = t-1$, and $t = 1$. □

Theorem 2.4 (Degenerate Hamilton-connectedness)**.** *Let $d \geq 0$ be an integer, let G be a nonempty d-degenerate graph, and let $k \geq d + 3$ be an integer. Then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamilton-connected.*

Proof. We proceed by induction on $n = |V(G)|$. If $n = 1$, then $\mathcal{R}_k(G) \cong K_k$, which is Hamilton-connected.

We next handle complete graphs $G = K_n$. The arrangement graph $A_{k,n}$ has as vertices the ordered n-tuples of distinct elements of $\{1, \ldots, k\}$, with two tuples adjacent if they differ in exactly one coordinate. Hence

$$\mathcal{R}_k(K_n) \cong A_{k,n}.$$

Since $n - 1 \leq d$, we have $k \geq d + 3 \geq n + 2$. By the Hamiltonian connectivity result of Hsu, Li, Tan and Hsu [4, Theorem 1], $A_{k,n}$ is Hamilton-connected.

We may therefore assume that G is not complete. Choose a vertex v_1 of minimum degree in G, and put

$$H := G - v_1.$$

The d-degeneracy of G gives $\deg_G(v_1) \le d$. Since G is not complete, its minimum degree is at most $n-2$, so there exists

$$w \in V(H) \setminus N_G(v_1).$$

In particular, H is nonempty. It is again d-degenerate, so by the induction hypothesis $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ is Hamilton-connected.

Let f be a k-colouring of H. We define

$$L(f) := \{1, \dots, k\} \setminus f(N_G(v_1)).$$

Thus $L(f)$ is precisely the set of colours that may be assigned to v_1 while extending f to a proper k-colouring of G. Since v_1 has at most d neighbors in G, we have

$$|L(f)| \ge k - d \ge 3.$$

For each $f \in V(\mathcal{R}_k(H))$, define the clique

$$F_f := \{f(c) : c \in L(f)\}.$$

Here $f(c)$ denotes the k-colouring of G that restricts to f on H and assigns the colour c to v_1. Thus F_f is a complete graph on $|L(f)|$ vertices.

Observation. Let f and g be adjacent vertices of $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$. Then f and g differ on exactly one vertex $u \in V(H)$. If $u \notin N_G(v_1)$, then

$$L(f) = L(g).$$

If $u \in N_G(v_1)$, then the forbidden colour set for v_1 loses at most one colour and gains at most one colour, and hence

$$|L(f) \cap L(g)| \ge |L(f)| - 1.$$

In particular,

$$|L(f) \cap L(g)| \ge 2.$$

The edges between the cliques F_f and F_g are precisely the edges

$$f(c)g(c) \qquad \text{with } c \in L(f) \cap L(g).$$

Lifting claim. Let

$$P : f_0, f_1, \dots, f_t$$

be a path in $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ with $t \ge 1$, and put

$$S_i := L(f_i) \cap L(f_{i+1}) \qquad (0 \le i \le t-1).$$

Suppose that $|S_j| \ge 3$ for at least one j. Given colours

$$a \in L(f_0), \qquad b \in L(f_t),$$

there is a Hamilton path in

$$\mathcal{R}_k(G)\Big[\bigcup_{i=0}^{t} F_{f_i}\Big]$$

from $f_0(a)$ to $f_t(b)$.

Indeed, by the observation, $|S_i| \geq 2$ for every i. Lemma 2.3 therefore provides bridge colours $x_i \in S_i$ such that

$$x_0 \neq a, \qquad x_i \neq x_{i-1} \ \ (1 \leq i \leq t-1), \qquad x_{t-1} \neq b.$$

Since each F_{f_i} is complete, choose Hamilton paths

$$\begin{aligned} P_0 &: \ f_0(a) \rightsquigarrow f_0(x_0) \quad \text{in } F_{f_0}, \\ P_i &: \ f_i(x_{i-1}) \rightsquigarrow f_i(x_i) \quad \text{in } F_{f_i} \qquad (1 \leq i \leq t-1), \\ P_t &: \ f_t(x_{t-1}) \rightsquigarrow f_t(b) \quad \text{in } F_{f_t}. \end{aligned}$$

For each $i \in \{0, \ldots, t-1\}$, the vertices $f_i(x_i)$ and $f_{i+1}(x_i)$ are adjacent in $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$. Concatenating the paths $P_0, P_1, \ldots, P_t$ along these bridge edges gives the required Hamilton path.

We now verify the additional hypothesis for the paths used below. Since H is k-colourable, permuting the colour names in a proper colouring shows that w takes all k colours among the vertices of $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$. In particular, $|V(\mathcal{R}_k(H))| \geq k \geq 3$. After deleting at most one colouring, at least $k-1 \geq 2$ different colours still occur at w. Thus every path containing all but at most one vertex of $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ has a step $f_j f_{j+1}$ that changes the colour of w. Since $w \notin N_G(v_1)$, this step satisfies

$$L(f_j) = L(f_{j+1}), \qquad |S_j| = |L(f_j)| \geq 3.$$

Consequently, the lifting claim applies to every such path.

Let

$$x = \alpha(a) \qquad \text{and} \qquad y = \beta(b)$$

be two distinct vertices of $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$, where $\alpha, \beta \in V(\mathcal{R}_k(H))$, $a \in L(\alpha)$, and $b \in L(\beta)$. We will show that there is a Hamilton path from x to y in $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$.

Case 1: $\alpha \neq \beta$. Since $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ is Hamilton-connected, there is a Hamilton path

$$\alpha = f_0, f_1, \ldots, f_t = \beta$$

in $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$. Since it contains every vertex of $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$, it satisfies the additional hypothesis of the lifting claim.

Applying the lifting claim to the path

$$f_0, f_1, \ldots, f_t$$

with the endpoint colours $a \in L(f_0)$ and $b \in L(f_t)$, we obtain a Hamilton path in

$$\mathcal{R}_k(G)\Big[\bigcup_{i=0}^{t} F_{f_i}\Big]$$

from $f_0(a) = x$ to $f_t(b) = y$. Since $f_0, \ldots, f_t$ exhaust all vertices of $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$, the cliques

$$F_{f_0}, F_{f_1}, \ldots, F_{f_t}$$

partition $V(\mathcal{R}_k(G))$. Therefore this path is a Hamilton path in $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ from x to y.

Case 2: $\alpha = \beta$. Here $a \neq b$. Choose $c \in L(\alpha) \setminus \{a, b\}$. Since H is nonempty and d-degenerate, it has a vertex u with $\deg_H(u) \leq d$. At least $k - d \geq 3$ colours are available at u, so recolour u to one different from both $\alpha(u)$ and c. This gives a base colouring g adjacent to α with $c \in L(g)$: no neighbour of v_1 has acquired colour c.

Every edge of a Hamilton-connected graph of order at least three lies on a Hamilton cycle, obtained by closing a Hamilton path between its ends. Take such a cycle C through αg, and let h be the other neighbour of α on C. Since $|L(\alpha) \cap L(h)| \geq 2$, choose

$$q \in (L(\alpha) \cap L(h)) \setminus \{c\}.$$

If $q = a$, interchange a, b and reverse the final path. Thus we may assume $q \neq a$. Partition F_α into two disjoint paths $P : \alpha(a) \rightsquigarrow \alpha(c)$ and $P' : \alpha(q) \rightsquigarrow \alpha(b)$: take P' to be a singleton if $q = b$, and otherwise the edge $\alpha(q)\alpha(b)$; place all remaining vertices in P. The distinct ends of P belong to this remaining clique, so this partition exists for every $|L(\alpha)| \geq 3$.

The path $C - \alpha$ contains all but one base state, so the lifting claim gives a spanning path Q through all other fibres from $g(c)$ to $h(q)$. The two cross edges $\alpha(c)g(c)$ and $h(q)\alpha(q)$ concatenate P, Q, P' into the required Hamilton path.

In both cases there is a Hamilton path from x to y. Therefore $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamilton-connected. □

Theorem 2.5 (Degenerate vertex-pancyclicity)**.** *Let $d \geq 0$ be an integer, let G be a nonempty d-degenerate graph, and let $k \geq d + 3$ be an integer. Then the recolouring graph $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is vertex-pancyclic.*

Proof. We proceed by induction on $|V(G)|$.

If $|V(G)| = 1$, then $\mathcal{R}_k(G) \cong K_k$. Since $k \geq 3$, every vertex of K_k lies on a cycle of every length from 3 to k. Thus the result holds.

Assume now that $|V(G)| \geq 2$, and suppose the result holds for all d-degenerate graphs with fewer vertices.

Choose a vertex v_1 of degree at most d, and put

$$H := G - v_1.$$

For each proper k-colouring f of H, define

$$L(f) := \{1, \ldots, k\} \setminus f(N_G(v_1)).$$

Thus $L(f)$ is the set of colours that can be assigned to v_1 while extending f to a proper k-colouring of G. Since $|N_G(v_1)| \leq d$, we have

$$|L(f)| \geq k - d \geq 3.$$

For each $f \in V(\mathcal{R}_k(H))$, define

$$F_f := \{f(c) : c \in L(f)\}.$$

Then F_f is a clique in $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$.

Let

$$X := \mathcal{R}_k(G), \qquad Y := \mathcal{R}_k(H).$$

The sets F_f, where $f \in V(Y)$, form a partition of $V(X)$.

As observed in the preceding proof, if f and g are adjacent in Y, then $|L(f) \cap L(g)| \geq 2$, and the edges between F_f and F_g are precisely $f(c)g(c)$ with $c \in L(f) \cap L(g)$.

Now fix an arbitrary vertex of X,

$$x = \alpha(a),$$

where $\alpha \in V(Y)$ and $a \in L(\alpha)$. We prove that x lies on a cycle of every possible length.

Let

$$M := |V(Y)|, \qquad N := |V(X)|.$$

Since H is nonempty, colour permutations give $M \geq k \geq 3$.

Closed lifting claim. Let

$$C : f_0, f_1, \ldots, f_{s-1}, f_0$$

be a cycle in Y with $s \geq 3$ and $f_0 = \alpha$. Then, for every integer ℓ satisfying

$$2s + 1 \leq \ell \leq \sum_{i=0}^{s-1} |F_{f_i}|,$$

there is a cycle in X through x of length ℓ using only vertices from the cliques $F_{f_0}, F_{f_1}, \ldots, F_{f_{s-1}}$.

For i modulo s, put

$$S_i := L(f_i) \cap L(f_{i+1}).$$

We first show that there are bridge colours $y_i \in S_i$ such that $y_{i-1} \neq y_i$ for every i modulo s.

By Lemma 2.1, such bridge colours exist unless s is odd and all the S_i are the same two-element set.

It remains to exclude the exceptional odd-cycle configuration in our setting. Suppose that s is odd and

$$S_0 = S_1 = \cdots = S_{s-1} = \{p, q\}.$$

For every i, the observation gives $2 = |S_i| \geq |L(f_i)| - 1$, so $|L(f_i)| = 3$. Consequently,

$$k - 3 = |f_i(N_G(v_1))| \leq \deg_G(v_1) \leq d \leq k - 3.$$

All inequalities are equalities. Thus $k = d + 3$, the vertex v_1 has exactly d neighbors, and these neighbors receive pairwise distinct colours under every f_i. None of these colours is p or q.

Every step $f_i f_{i+1}$ changes a vertex in $N_G(v_1)$; otherwise $L(f_i) = L(f_{i+1})$ would imply $|S_i| = 3$. In particular, $d \geq 1$. Fix an ordering $u_1, \ldots, u_d$ of $N_G(v_1)$, and let

$$A := \{1, \ldots, k\} \setminus \{p, q\}.$$

For each i, exactly one colour $r_i \in A$ is absent from $f_i(N_G(v_1))$. Hence

$$(f_i(u_1), \ldots, f_i(u_d), r_i)$$

is a permutation of the $d + 1$ colours in A. At the step $f_i f_{i+1}$, the changed neighbor must receive r_i, because the other neighbor colours remain fixed and pairwise distinct. Its old colour becomes r_{i+1}. Thus this step exchanges the entries at one neighbor position and the last position, reversing the parity of the permutation. Since $f_s = f_0$, an odd number of such exchanges cannot return to the initial permutation. This contradiction excludes the exceptional configuration, and proves the existence of the colours y_i.

The integer intervals

$$[3, |F_{f_0}|],\ [2, |F_{f_1}|], \ldots, [2, |F_{f_{s-1}}|]$$

have sum equal to the full integer interval $[2s + 1, \sum_i |F_{f_i}|]$. We may therefore choose integers $m_0, \ldots, m_{s-1}$ with

$$3 \leq m_0 \leq |F_{f_0}|, \qquad 2 \leq m_i \leq |F_{f_i}| \quad (1 \leq i \leq s - 1), \qquad \sum_{i=0}^{s-1} m_i = \ell.$$

Inside F_{f_0} take a path from $f_0(y_{s-1})$ to $f_0(y_0)$ on m_0 vertices and containing x. For $1 \leq i \leq s - 1$, take inside F_{f_i} a path from $f_i(y_{i-1})$ to $f_i(y_i)$ on m_i vertices. The inequalities $y_{i-1} \neq y_i$ make these

paths possible, and the bridge edges $f_i(y_i)f_{i+1}(y_i)$, with indices modulo s, close them into the desired cycle.

Since $|L(\alpha)| \geq 3$, the clique F_α contains a triangle through x.

Next we show that x lies on cycles of lengths $4, 5, 6$. Since H is nonempty and d-degenerate, choose a vertex $u \in V(H)$ of degree at most d in H. Because $k \geq d+3$, we can recolour u to some colour different from its present colour, avoiding all colours on $N_H(u)$ and, if $u \in N_G(v_1)$, also avoiding the colour a. Thus there is a colouring β adjacent to α in Y such that

$$a \in L(\beta).$$

Since

$$|L(\alpha) \cap L(\beta)| \geq 2,$$

choose

$$p \in L(\alpha) \cap L(\beta), \qquad p \neq a.$$

Also choose

$$q \in L(\alpha) \setminus \{a, p\}$$

and

$$r \in L(\beta) \setminus \{a, p\}.$$

Then the following are cycles in X through x:

$$\alpha(a), \alpha(p), \beta(p), \beta(a), \alpha(a),$$

of length 4;

$$\alpha(a), \alpha(q), \alpha(p), \beta(p), \beta(a), \alpha(a),$$

of length 5; and

$$\alpha(a), \alpha(q), \alpha(p), \beta(p), \beta(r), \beta(a), \alpha(a),$$

of length 6.

It remains to construct cycles of all lengths $\ell \geq 7$. By induction, for each $3 \leq s \leq M$ choose a cycle C_s of length s in Y through α, and put

$$T_s := \sum_{f \in V(C_s)} |F_f|.$$

The closed lifting claim gives every length in $[2s+1, T_s]$ through x. These intervals overlap consecutively, since $T_s \geq 3s$ and the next lower endpoint satisfies $2s+3 \leq 3s$ for $s \geq 3$. Moreover, $T_M = N$, because C_M is spanning. Hence the intervals cover every length from 7 to N. Together with the cycles of lengths $3, 4, 5, 6$ constructed above, this proves the claim.

Since x was arbitrary, $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is vertex-pancyclic. □

Corollary 2.6. *Every nonempty d-degenerate graph has a Hamiltonian $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ for $k \geq d+3$; it is Hamilton-connected and vertex-pancyclic in the same range.*

3 Endpoint lifting and restoration

A colouring of a deleted graph determines the available colours at the vertices to be restored. The resulting extension graph is a fibre. In all the constructions below, assignments retain their actual coordinate values: equal assignments in two different fibres are distinct vertices, and a cross edge joins their two copies. In particular, a move of one vertex of the deleted graph may change several available lists at once.

Lemma 3.1 (Products of complete graphs)**.** *Let $s \geq 1$ and $F = \square_{j=1}^{s} K_{A_j}$, where every A_j is finite and $|A_j| \geq 2$. If all lists have size two, F has a Hamilton path between two prescribed vertices if and only if those vertices lie in opposite bipartition classes. If at least one list has size at least three, F is Hamilton-connected.*

Proof. In the binary case F is the hypercube Q_s, whose bipartition classes have equal size. The endpoint condition is therefore necessary. For sufficiency, induct on s, starting with the single edge Q_1. Choose a coordinate on which the prescribed endpoints differ and split along it. Their projections into Q_{s-1} have the same parity. Choose a projected vertex of the opposite parity; use the two induction paths to and from its copies, joined by the edge between those copies.

For the second assertion, we first show that $Y \square K_r$ is Hamilton-connected whenever Y is Hamilton-connected and $|V(Y)| \geq 3$. Induct on r, starting with $r = 1$. If the two endpoints lie in different copies of Y, order the copies starting and ending at those copies. Choose successive bridge vertices in $V(Y)$, with the first different from the first endpoint projection, consecutive bridges different, and the last different from the last endpoint projection. Such choices exist because $|V(Y)| \geq 3$: choose greedily, leaving the last bridge until the end, when it has at most two forbidden values. Prescribed-end Hamilton paths inside the copies then join into a spanning path. If both endpoints lie in one copy, take a Hamilton path between them there and choose an edge xy of it. By induction the other $r - 1$ copies have a spanning path from a copy of x to a copy of y in the same one of those copies. Insert that path in place of xy, using the two cross edges. Start with a complete-graph factor of order at least three and add the remaining factors to obtain the claim. □

Lemma 3.2 (Endpoint product-fibre lift)**.** *Let $m \geq 3$, $s \geq 1$, and let*

$$F_i = \square_{j=1}^{s} K_{A_{i,j}}, \qquad |A_{i,j}| \geq 2, \qquad 0 \leq i < m,$$

be disjoint fibres arranged along a path. Join equal assignments in consecutive fibres. At every transition assume that at least one list is unchanged and that, for every coordinate,

$$|A_{i,j} \setminus A_{i+1,j}| \leq 1, \qquad |A_{i+1,j} \setminus A_{i,j}| \leq 1.$$

If an internal fibre F_r, $1 \leq r \leq m-2$, has a factor of order at least three, then every prescribed $p \in F_0$ and $q \in F_{m-1}$ are joined by a path covering all vertices of all fibres exactly once.

Proof. Write

$$J_i = \square_{j=1}^{s} K_{A_{i,j} \cap A_{i+1,j}}$$

for the graph of common assignments. The intersections are nonempty, and an unchanged coordinate supplies an edge of J_i.

Starting at p, record the reachable exit assignments at each interface. If a fibre has a reachable entrance a, an interface edge has an admissible Hamilton-path endpoint: in a binary fibre choose its endpoint of parity opposite to a, and in a nonbinary fibre choose an endpoint different from a. Lemma 3.1 therefore shows that the reachable set never becomes empty.

At F_r, its outgoing interface J_r still contains an edge after any one assignment is removed. Indeed, if its large coordinate is unchanged, J_r contains a triangle. Otherwise that coordinate has intersection size at least two, and a different unchanged coordinate supplies a $K_2\square K_2$. Take a reachable entrance a in F_r. Hamilton-connectedness of F_r makes every assignment in $V(J_r)\setminus\{a\}$ reachable; this set contains an entire edge.

An incoming reachable edge permits every outgoing assignment to be reached in the next fibre. In a binary fibre the two endpoints of the edge have opposite parities, so one has the parity needed for any specified outgoing assignment. In a nonbinary fibre they are distinct, so one differs from that assignment. Thus the reachable exits contain an edge at every subsequent interface. At the last fibre, one endpoint of the incoming edge can be joined to the specified q. Backtracking the finite choices supplies one Hamilton path in each fibre; the actual cross edges concatenate them into the required spanning path. □

Lemma 3.3 (Hamilton-connected independent-set restoration)**.** *Let S be a nonempty independent set, $H = G - S \neq \varnothing$, and $k \geq 4$. Suppose*

$$d_G(u) \leq k-2 \quad (u \in S), \qquad |N_G(x) \cap S| \leq |S| - 1 \quad (x \in V(H)).$$

Assume that $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ is Hamilton-connected and that some proper k-colouring of H leaves at least three colours available at a vertex of S. If α, β are proper k-colourings of G with $\alpha|_H \neq \beta|_H$, then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ has an α–β Hamilton path.

Proof. Take a Hamilton path of $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ between the two restriction colourings. For a base colouring f, the fibre is exactly

$$\square_{u\in S} K_{A_f(u)}, \qquad A_f(u) = [k] \setminus f(N_G(u)).$$

Every list is at least binary. A move at an actual vertex x of H leaves the list of at least one non-neighbour in S unchanged; every other list loses and gains at most one colour. These are the transition conditions of Lemma 3.2, even when several lists change together.

A colouring with a nonbinary fibre has at least k distinct colour permutations: fix a vertex of the nonempty H and send its colour to each of the k labels. Every resulting fibre is nonbinary. The base Hamilton path has only two endpoints, so one of these colourings is internal. Lemma 3.2 now lifts the path with the specified, actual colours of α and β on S. □

For use of this lemma, first choose a vertex w on which two prescribed colourings differ, and then choose S with $w \notin S$. This ensures different restriction colourings; the lemma does not claim to handle arbitrary endpoints in the same fibre.

Lemma 3.4 (Cyclic product-fibre lift)**.** *Let $m \geq 3$ disjoint fibres $F_i = \square_{j=1}^{s} K_{A_{i,j}}$, with $s \geq 1$ and $|A_{i,j}| \geq 2$, be cyclically ordered. Join equal assignments in consecutive fibres and define $J_i = \square_j K_{A_{i,j}\cap A_{i+1,j}}$, with indices modulo m. Suppose every J_i contains an edge, F_0 has a factor of order at least three, and there are distinct edges $e_0 \in E(J_0)$ and $e_{m-1} \in E(J_{m-1})$ (compared as actual assignment pairs). Then the layered graph has a Hamilton cycle.*

Proof. Choose an edge e_i in every remaining interface, and choose $z_0 \in V(e_0) \setminus V(e_{m-1})$. For $1 \leq i < m$, there is a bijection $\phi_i : V(e_{i-1}) \to V(e_i)$ such that each $z, \phi_i(z)$ is an admissible pair of Hamilton-path endpoints in F_i. In a binary fibre match opposite parities. Otherwise use a bijection with no fixed assignment, which always exists between two two-element sets: interchange equal sets, send a common member to the other target member when there is exactly one common member, and use either bijection when the sets are disjoint.

Put $z_i = \phi_i(z_{i-1})$. Traverse F_i from z_{i-1} to z_i for $1 \le i < m$. Since $z_{m-1} \in V(e_{m-1})$, $z_{m-1} \neq z_0$, so the nonbinary F_0 has a Hamilton path from z_{m-1} to z_0. Join the fibre paths by the cross edges at the assignments z_i. They cover every fibre once and form one cycle. □

Lemma 3.5 (Independent-set restoration)**.** *Let S be a nonempty independent set, $H = G - S \neq \varnothing$, and $k \ge 4$. Suppose*

$$d_G(u) \le k-2 \quad (u \in S), \qquad |N_G(x) \cap S| \le |S| - 1 \quad (x \in V(H)).$$

If $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ is Hamiltonian and some proper k-colouring of H leaves at least three colours available at a vertex of S, then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamiltonian.

Proof. Take a Hamilton cycle of the base and use the same product fibres as in Lemma 3.3. Every interface contains an edge. Index a nonbinary fibre as F_0 and choose a large coordinate in it. At either adjacent interface, that coordinate supplies a triangle if unchanged, or a $K_2 \square K_2$ together with a different unchanged coordinate if it changes. Thus both adjacent interfaces have at least two edges, and distinct edges e_0, e_{m-1} can be chosen. Apply Lemma 3.4. □

Lemma 3.6 (Single-vertex Hamilton-connected lift)**.** *Let $H = G - v \neq \varnothing$, $k \ge 4$, and $k \ge d_G(v) + 3$. Assume that v has a non-neighbour in G, $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$ is Hamilton-connected, and $\delta(\mathcal{R}_k(H)) > d_G(v)$. Then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamilton-connected.*

Proof. For a base colouring f, write $A_f = [k] \setminus f(N_G(v))$. The fibre is the clique K_{A_f}, $|A_f| \ge 3$, and adjacent base fibres have intersections of size at least two.

Let w be a non-neighbour of v. Any base path covering all states, or all but one state, has a step changing w. Indeed, global colour permutations show that w takes all k colours among the base states; omitting one state leaves at least $k - 1 \ge 3$ colours. At a step changing w, the available list for v is unchanged, so its intersection has size at least three. Consequently such a base path can be lifted with arbitrary prescribed first and last fibre colours. Indeed, Lemma 2.3 supplies bridge colours in the successive intersections, with distinct entrance and exit colours in each clique and with the prescribed endpoint colours avoided at the two ends. Traverse each clique between these colours and join the paths by the corresponding cross edges.

If the prescribed states lie in different fibres, lift the base Hamilton path between their restrictions. Suppose instead that both lie over f, with distinct colours a, b. A Hamilton-connected graph with at least three vertices has a Hamilton cycle through every edge: close a Hamilton path between the ends of the edge by that edge. Here the base has at least k states.

Choose any $c \in A_f \setminus \{a, b\}$. At most $d_G(v)$ base moves from f make c unavailable: for each neighbour of v, only its move to colour c can do so. The state-degree assumption therefore gives a base edge fg preserving c. Take a base Hamilton cycle C containing fg, and let h be the other neighbour of f on C. Choose $q \in (A_f \cap A_h) \setminus \{c\}$, which is possible because the intersection has size at least two. If $q = a$, interchange the endpoints and reverse the final path, so we may assume $q \neq a$.

As in the same-fibre case of Theorem 2.4, split the root clique into disjoint paths $a \rightsquigarrow c$ and $q \rightsquigarrow b$ covering it; the second is a singleton when $q = b$, and otherwise is the edge qb. Lift $C - f$ through all other fibres with endpoint colours c, q. Joining this lifted path to the two root paths by the cross edges at c, q gives the prescribed spanning path.

□

A Hamilton-connected graph of order at least four has minimum degree at least three. A vertex of degree two would, with its neighbours chosen as the two endpoints, force a spanning path to have

only three vertices; degrees zero and one are excluded as well. Every nonempty colourable H has at least k states in $\mathcal{R}_k(H)$, by colour permutation. These observations will supply the state-degree condition in the low-degree inductions.

4 Hamilton-connected planar classes

4.1 All planar graphs

We first establish the marked structural statement needed to retain a coordinate on which the prescribed endpoint colourings differ.

Lemma 4.1 (Separated degree-five vertices with a marked vertex)**.** *If G is planar and $\delta(G) \geq 5$, then, for any $w \in V(G)$, there are two degree-five vertices different from w whose distance is at least three. Vertices in different components have infinite distance.*

Proof. Extend G, without adding vertices, to a simple plane triangulation T. A degree-five vertex in T still has degree five in G, and a pair at distance at least three in T has that property in G. Moreover $\delta(T) \geq 5$. It suffices to prove the assertion in T. Euler's formula gives at least twelve degree-five vertices.

For a degree-five vertex x, put $W = N_T[x]$, $U = V(T) \setminus W$, $r = |U|$, and let B be the vertices at distance exactly two from x; write $b = |B|$. The five neighbours of x form a cycle in their cyclic order, so $e_T(W) \geq 10$. Contract the connected W and simplify parallel edges. The resulting plane graph has $r + 1$ vertices and $e_T(U) + b$ edges. As $|V(T)| \geq 12$, the planar edge bound gives $e_T(U) + b \leq 3r - 3$. Since $e(T) = 3r + 12$,

$$\sum_{z \in U} d_T(z) = e_T(U) + e(T) - e_T(W) \leq 6r - b - 1.$$

Let F_x be the degree-five vertices at distance at least three from x. The same sum is exactly

$$6r - b - |F_x| + \sum_{z \in B} (d_T(z) - 5) + \sum_{\substack{z \in U \setminus B \\ d_T(z) \geq 6}} (d_T(z) - 6).$$

It follows that $|F_x| \geq 1$, and if $|F_x| = 1$, every vertex of B has degree five.

Suppose every pair of degree-five vertices at distance at least three contains w, and let L be all degree-five vertices except w. For every $x \in L$, the nonempty F_x must be $\{w\}$. Hence w is at distance at least three from L, and every vertex at distance exactly two from x belongs to L. Take a shortest path from w to L, ending at x. The vertex two steps before x is also in L and is closer to w, a contradiction. □

Theorem 4.2 (Planar Hamilton-connectedness)**.** *For every nonempty planar graph G and every $k \geq 7$, $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamilton-connected. Consequently $h(\text{Planar}) = \text{hc}(\text{Planar}) = 7$.*

Proof. Prove the seven-colour assertion by induction on $|V(G)|$, allowing disconnected graphs throughout. If $|V(G)| \leq 5$, the graph is four-degenerate and Theorem 2.4 applies. For $|V(G)| \geq 6$, a vertex v of degree at most four has a non-neighbour. The smaller $H = G - v$ is Hamilton-connected by induction. For every seven-colouring f of H, which has at least five vertices,

$$d_{\mathcal{R}_7(H)}(f) = \sum_{x \in V(H)} (6 - |f(N_H(x))|) \geq 6|V(H)| - 2|E(H)| \geq 12 > d_G(v).$$

Lemma 3.6 restores v.

Otherwise $\delta(G) \geq 5$. For prescribed distinct colourings α, β, choose an actual vertex w with $\alpha(w) \neq \beta(w)$. Lemma 4.1 supplies $S = \{u, v\}$, avoiding w, with $d(u) = d(v) = 5$ and $d_G(u, v) \geq 3$. Thus S is independent, no outside vertex is adjacent to both members, and $H = G - S$ is smaller and nonempty. Choose two nonadjacent neighbours x, y of u; they exist since its five neighbours cannot induce a planar K_5. Properly six-colour the planar $H - \{x, y\}$, and give both x, y colour seven. This is a proper colouring of H in which the neighbours of u use at most four colours, leaving at least three available. The restriction colourings differ at w, so Lemma 3.3 gives an α–β Hamilton path.

For $k \geq 8$, planar five-degeneracy and Theorem 2.4 suffice. For sharpness, colour the six antipodal vertex pairs of the icosahedron with six different colours. Each vertex sees all other five colours, so this is a frozen proper six-colouring; its recolouring graph has more than one state and is disconnected. Thus both thresholds are seven. □

Planar five-degeneracy and Theorem 2.5 also give vertex-pancyclicity for $k \geq 8$.

4.2 Triangle-free and bipartite planar graphs

The critical five-colour step needs an adjacent-pair fibre, which is not a product of complete graphs. We give its finite input separately from the arbitrary-size lifting argument.

For $A, B \subseteq \{0, 1, 2, 3, 4\}$, put

$$F(A, B) = \{(a, b) \in A \times B : a \neq b\},$$

with adjacency given by changing one coordinate. When $|A|, |B|$ are three or four, exchange the coordinates if necessary so that $|A| \leq |B|$. There are exactly seven types $(|A|, |B|, |A \cap B|)$.

Lemma 4.3 (Adjacent-pair edge cycles and exits)**.** *For each of the seven types*

$$331, 332, 333, 342, 343, 443, 444,$$

every edge of $F(A, B)$ lies on a Hamilton cycle. The type 333 is itself a 6-cycle. The types $342, 343, 443, 444$ are Hamilton-connected. If J is the common state set of one of the interfaces allowed in Lemma 4.4, then every $p \in F(A, B)$ has a neighbour $q \in J$, and hence a p–q Hamilton path in $F(A, B)$.

Proof. The companion certificate gives one short Hamilton cycle for each of the seven representatives and checks its orbit under the independent row and column permutations that agree on $A \cap B$ (with the stated side exchange for type 332). The resulting edge orbits are the full edge sets. The preserved endpoint words prove the four Hamilton-connected types (indeed, the stronger original endpoint classification). These are finite local checks; no arbitrary-size claim is being inferred from them.

It remains to check the interface exit. If neither list changes, take a row or column neighbour of p. If a 3-list A changes to A' and $A_0 = A \cap A'$, then $|A_0| = 2$: for $p = (a, b)$ choose (a, d) with $d \in B \setminus \{a, b\}$ when $a \in A_0$, and choose (c, b) with $c \in A_0 \setminus \{b\}$ otherwise. The other one-list change is symmetric. When a 3-list and a containing 4-list are interchanged, change the other coordinate to the other colour in the common 3-list. In every case the selected edge lies on a Hamilton cycle, so deleting it gives the required Hamilton path. □

Lemma 4.4 (Adjacent-pair interfaces and reset)**.** *Arrange full fibres $F(A_i, B_i)$ along a base path. Each list has size three or four in a fixed five-colour palette. At each step either both lists stay unchanged, or one stays unchanged and the other is replaced by a three-element list differing in one colour, or a three-element list and a containing four-element list are interchanged. Join the copies of equal assignments at consecutive layers. If an internal layer has $|A_r| = |B_r| = 4$, there is a spanning path between any prescribed first-layer and last-layer states.*

Proof. First consider one allowed interface between $F(A, B)$ and $F(A', B')$, and write J for their common assignment set. The preceding lemma supplies, in both directions, a Hamilton path from every entrance state to some state of J.

Use this property to propagate nonempty sets of reachable exits from the prescribed first state. The internal 44 layer is Hamilton-connected, and its outgoing interface has at least nine states. Any reachable entrance p can therefore reach all interface states except possibly p, yielding at least two distinct reachable exits. The next layer still has one four-element list and is one of $342, 343, 443, 444$, hence is Hamilton-connected. Two distinct reachable entrances let every state of that layer be an exit. If it is the last layer, this includes the prescribed endpoint. Otherwise its entire outgoing interface is reachable.

Thereafter this property propagates: for a specified exit q in the current layer, apply the one-interface property in reverse to find a Hamilton-path entrance in its fully reachable incoming interface. The last prescribed endpoint is therefore reachable. Backtracking gives one Hamilton path in every full fibre, joined by actual cross edges, with no repetition or omission. □

Theorem 4.5 (Triangle-free planar Hamilton-connectedness)**.** *If G is a nonempty triangle-free planar graph, then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamilton-connected for every $k \geq 5$. For the class of nonempty triangle-free planar graphs, $h = \mathrm{hc} = 5$.*

Proof. For $k \geq 6$, use three-degeneracy and Theorem 2.4. For $k = 5$, induct on the order of G, permitting disconnected graphs. Orders at most three are handled by two-degeneracy and the same theorem. At larger orders a vertex v of degree at most two has a non-neighbour. The induction hypothesis gives a Hamilton-connected base of at least five states, thus of minimum degree at least three; Lemma 3.6 applies.

Assume now $\delta(G) \geq 3$. Let L be its degree-three vertices and $s = |L|$. The triangle-free planar edge bound gives

$$s \geq 8 + \sum_{d_G(z) \geq 4} (d_G(z) - 4).$$

Given distinct α, β, choose w on which they differ. There are two exhaustive cases.

If $L \setminus \{w\}$ contains adjacent u, v, denote their other neighbours by u_1, u_2 and v_1, v_2. The four actual outside vertices are distinct: a common neighbour of u and v would form a triangle. In $H = G - \{u, v\}$ the restriction endpoints still differ at w, so induction gives a base Hamilton path between them. Its fibre over f is

$$F(A_f, B_f), \qquad A_f = [5] \setminus \{f(u_1), f(u_2)\}, \quad B_f = [5] \setminus \{f(v_1), f(v_2)\}.$$

The lists have size three or four. One actual base move affects at most one of them and gives precisely an interface allowed in Lemma 4.4. Edges among the four outside vertices restrict the base colourings, but do not alter this statement.

There is a base colouring with both lists four-element: use Grötzsch's theorem [6] to three-colour $H - \{u_1, u_2, v_1, v_2\}$, then give u_1, u_2 colour four and v_1, v_2 colour five. Each pair is independent by triangle-freeness, and edges across the pairs have distinct colours. At least five global colour

permutations give distinct double-four-list base states. Since the Hamilton path has only two endpoints, one is internal. Apply Lemma 4.4 with the specified local endpoint states to complete the restoration.

Otherwise $S = L \setminus \{w\}$ is independent and has at least $s - 1 \geq 7$ vertices. For any outside vertex z of degree at least four, the displayed Euler budget implies $d_G(z) \leq s - 4 < |S|$. The only possible degree-three outside vertex is w, whose degree is also less than $|S|$. Thus no outside vertex sees all of S. Choose $u \in S$ and two of its neighbours x, y. They are nonadjacent. Three-colour $H - \{x, y\}$ by Grötzsch's theorem and give both x, y colour five. At most two colours then occur on the three neighbours of u, so u has at least three available colours. All conditions of Lemma 3.3 hold, and w is retained; it gives the desired endpoint path.

For sharpness, on the cube Q_3 view the colours as $\mathbb{Z}_2^2$ and set

$$f(x, y, z) = x(1, 0) + y(0, 1) + z(1, 1).$$

The three neighbours of every vertex have all three other colours, so the colouring is frozen and the complete four-colour recolouring graph is disconnected. The upper and lower bounds give both thresholds. □

Corollary 4.6. *The class of nonempty bipartite planar graphs has $h = \mathrm{hc} = 5$. For every graph in this class, $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is vertex-pancyclic for $k \geq 6$.*

Proof. Bipartite planar graphs are triangle-free, and the cube belongs to this class. The vertex-pancyclic assertion follows from three-degeneracy and Theorem 2.5. □

The same vertex-pancyclic bound $k \geq 6$ holds for all triangle-free planar graphs. This conclusion uses the degenerate theorem separately from Hamilton-connectedness.

4.3 Girth at least six and forests

Lemma 4.7 (Separated degree-two vertices with a marked vertex)**.** *If G is planar, $\mathrm{g}(G) \geq 6$, and $\delta(G) \geq 2$, then for any $w \in V(G)$ there are two degree-two vertices different from w whose distance is at least three.*

Proof. Every component has a cycle, and the girth-six Euler bound gives at least six degree-two vertices per component. If there are at least two components, choose such a vertex different from w in each of two components. Suppose G is connected and let n_2 be its number of degree-two vertices. From $2|E(G)| \leq 3|V(G)| - 6$,

$$n_2 \geq 6 + \sum_{d_G(z) \geq 3} (d_G(z) - 3).$$

Let L consist of all degree-two vertices except w; then $|L| \geq n_2 - 1 \geq 5$. Suppose all pairs in L have distance at most two.

If $u, v \in L$ are adjacent, let a, b be their respective other neighbours. The absence of cycles of length at most five implies that the intersection of the two closed distance-two balls is exactly $\{u, v, a, b\}$, and that $d_G(a, b) = 3$. Thus at most three of these vertices can lie in L, a contradiction.

Otherwise L is independent. Its two-element neighbourhoods are pairwise intersecting; they are distinct because there is no four-cycle. At least four distinct pairwise intersecting two-element sets have a common element: if $\{a, b\}, \{a, c\}$ occur and a third set omits a, it must be $\{b, c\}$, after which no fourth distinct set is possible. Hence some vertex z is adjacent to all of L. Then $d_G(z) \geq n_2 - 1 \geq 5$, whereas the Euler inequality gives

$$n_2 \geq 6 + d_G(z) - 3 \geq n_2 + 2,$$

a contradiction. □

Theorem 4.8 (Girth at least six)**.** *For every finite integer $g \geq 6$, the class of nonempty planar graphs of girth at least g has $h = \mathrm{hc} = 4$. Every graph G in this class has Hamilton-connected $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ for $k \geq 4$, and vertex-pancyclic $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ for $k \geq 5$.*

Proof. For $k \geq 5$, use two-degeneracy and Theorems 2.4 and 2.5. At $k = 4$, induct on the order, starting with orders at most two, which are forests and covered by the one-degenerate theorem. If $|V(G)| \geq 3$ and $d_G(v) \leq 1$, then v has a non-neighbour. The smaller nonempty base is Hamilton-connected by induction and has at least four states, hence minimum degree at least three. Restore v using Lemma 3.6.

Otherwise apply Lemma 4.7 to a vertex w at which the prescribed endpoint colourings differ. It gives separated degree-two vertices u, v, both different from w. Set $S = \{u, v\}$ and $H = G - S$. The set S is independent, no outside vertex sees both its members, and H is nonempty. The neighbours x, y of u are nonadjacent. The two-degenerate $H - \{x, y\}$ can be three-coloured; giving x, y colour four leaves three colours available at u. Lemma 3.3 now restores a Hamilton path between the actual prescribed states.

For the lower bound, take a cycle of length at least g divisible by three and repeat the colours $0, 1, 2$ around it. This is a frozen proper three-colouring, so its complete three-colour recolouring graph is disconnected. Both class thresholds are therefore four. □

Theorem 4.9 (Forests)**.** *The class of nonempty forests has $h = \mathrm{hc} = 4$. Every such forest F has Hamilton-connected and vertex-pancyclic $\mathcal{R}_k(F)$ for $k \geq 4$.*

Proof. The upper bounds follow from one-degeneracy and Theorems 2.4 and 2.5. For the Hamiltonian lower bound, $\mathcal{R}_3(P_3)$ has twelve states. Its six states using three distinct colours have degree two, so every edge incident with them is forced in a spanning cycle. For each of the three middle-vertex colours b, these forced edges form a 4-cycle

$$(a, b, a), (c, b, a), (c, b, c), (a, b, c), \qquad \{a, b, c\} = \{0, 1, 2\}.$$

The three disjoint forced cycles prevent a Hamilton cycle. For the Hamilton-connected lower bound, the subgraph $\mathcal{R}_3(K_2) = C_6$ is already not Hamilton-connected. □

5 Hamiltonian four-colour subclasses at girth five

The results in this section are Hamiltonian results. They do not assert Hamilton-connectedness at four colours. The local models are defined below; their finite witnesses are supplied in the supplementary certificate, not printed in the article. Their finite parts classify labelled lists; the inductions are valid for an arbitrary number of vertices and are not extrapolations from finite state spaces.

For both subclasses in this section the four-colour Hamilton-connected question remains open. The four-colour proofs splice Hamilton cycles of smaller recolouring graphs. The available Hamilton-connected restoration lemma only covers endpoints whose restrictions to the smaller graph differ; the adjacent-degree-two, path-$(2, 3, 2)$, separated-pair, and protected-pentagon steps have no endpoint-preserving analogue here. Thus the threshold table records $4 \leq \mathrm{hc} \leq 5$, rather than $\mathrm{hc} = 4$.

Lemma 5.1 (Subdivided-star lift)**.** *Let $S = \{u_1, \ldots, u_s\}$ be independent, $s \geq 3$, and suppose $N(u_i) = \{w, x_i\}$, where $N(w) = S$, $w \notin S$, and the x_i are distinct and belong to $J = G - (S \cup \{w\})$. If $\mathcal{R}_4(J)$ is Hamiltonian and some proper colouring of J gives the same colour to two distinct x_i, then $\mathcal{R}_4(G)$ is Hamiltonian.*

Proof. Take a Hamilton cycle C of $\mathcal{R}_4(J)$. Choose three distinct edges of C. At each edge at most one x_i changes, so an unchanged x_j supplies a colour a_r at the rth chosen edge. Choose a tree on the four colours whose three edges contain a_1, a_2, a_3, respectively (a star works when there is one repeated label; if the labels are all distinct, use the star at the fourth colour). Make four copies of C, indexed by the colour of w, and splice the corresponding copies along the three selected edges according to that colour tree. The result is a Hamilton cycle B of $\mathcal{R}_4(G - S)$ with the following control: whenever w changes from a to b along B, some x_j has colour a or b.

Over a base colouring f the u_i-lists are

$$A_i(f) = [4] \setminus \{f(w), f(x_i)\}.$$

They have size at least two. At a move in J, one list changes and another coordinate is unchanged. At a move of w, all intersections are $[4] \setminus \{a, b, f(x_i)\}$, and the control property leaves a coordinate with a two-element intersection. Thus the product-fibre splice applies at every step. At the base colouring with $f(x_p) = f(x_q)$, give w that same colour; the two corresponding lists have size three, so both interfaces at this fibre contain two distinct splice edges. The resulting cycle traverses all extensions and proves the lemma. □

Lemma 5.2 (Five-face identity)**.** *Let C be a connected plane graph of girth at least five and minimum degree at least two. Let p be the number of 5-faces, $Q = \sum_{|F|\geq 7}(|F| - 6)$, $s = |\{v : d(v) = 2\}|$, and $D = \sum_v (d(v) - 3)$ over vertices of degree at least three. Then*

$$p = 12 + Q + 2D - 2s.$$

Every 5-face is a simple 5-cycle, and distinct faces give distinct cycles unless $C = C_5$.

Proof. A facial walk has no immediate reversal and contains a cycle, hence has length at least five. Counting face lengths gives $2e = 6f - p + Q$, while the degree sum is $2e = 3n - s + D$; with $n - e + f = 2$, subtraction yields the identity. A repeated vertex on a facial walk of length five would give a shorter cycle. If one 5-cycle bounds two faces, all its vertices have degree two and connectedness gives $C = C_5$. □

Corollary 5.3 (Two-degeneracy from seven pentagons)**.** *A planar graph of girth at least five with at most seven distinct 5-cycles is two-degenerate.*

Proof. Otherwise a connected subgraph has minimum degree at least three. In its plane embedding the identity has $s = 0$, and therefore at least twelve 5-faces, which are distinct 5-cycles. This contradicts the hypothesis. □

Theorem 5.4 (At most seven distinct five-cycles)**.** *Let G be a nonempty planar graph with girth at least five and at most seven distinct 5-cycles. Then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamiltonian for every $k \geq 4$; therefore the Hamiltonian threshold of this class is four. No four-colour Hamilton-connected conclusion is claimed.*

Proof. For $k = 4$ use induction on $|V(G)|$, allowing disconnected graphs. The one-vertex graph gives K_4. A vertex of degree at most one is restored by Lemma 2.2. If two degree-two vertices are adjacent, use Lemma 5.5. Otherwise the degree-two vertices form an independent set S. In a component containing a cycle, Lemma 5.2 and the bound $p \leq 7$ give $|S| \geq 3$; a tree component has a leaf and was already reduced.

If no vertex is adjacent to all of S, every vertex outside S has at most $|S| - 1$ neighbours in S. Choose $u \in S$ with neighbours x, y. They are nonadjacent by the girth condition. Three-colour

$G - S - \{x, y\}$ greedily using Corollary 5.3, and colour both x, y with a fourth colour. This gives a base colouring with three colours available at u. Lemma 3.5 restores S.

Suppose that a vertex w is adjacent to all of S. In the component under consideration write $d(w) = |S| + t$. The identity and $D \geq d(w) - 3$ give $p \geq 6 + Q + 2t$, so $p \leq 7$ forces $t = 0$ and $N(w) = S$. Write $N(u_i) = \{w, x_i\}$. The x_i are distinct, and two are nonadjacent since $|S| \geq 3$ and the graph has no triangle. Put $J = G - (S \cup \{w\})$. Greedy three-colouring of $J - \{x_p, x_q\}$ followed by assigning the fourth colour to x_p, x_q supplies the hypothesis of Lemma 5.1; induction on J completes this case. For $k \geq 5$, apply the degenerate Hamiltonian theorem to the corollary above (and use the one-vertex lift at each deletion); this is a separate argument and assumes no monotonicity in k. □

Lemma 5.5 (Adjacent degree-two restoration)**.** *Let u, v be adjacent degree-two vertices, with $N(u) = \{v, x\}$ and $N(v) = \{u, y\}$, where $x \neq y$. If $\mathcal{R}_4(G - \{u, v\})$ is Hamiltonian, then $\mathcal{R}_4(G)$ is Hamiltonian.*

Proof. For a base colouring f, the extension fibre is $F(A, B)$, where $A = [4] \setminus \{f(x)\}$ and $B = [4] \setminus \{f(y)\}$. For $A = B = \{a, b, c\}$ use the cycle (ab, ac, bc, ba, ca, cb); for $A = \{a, b, c\}$, $B = \{a, b, d\}$ use $(ab, ad, bd, ba, ca, cd, cb)$.

In fact, any two fibre Hamilton cycles have at least two common edges when at most one list changes. For an unchanged fibre, equal lists give C_6, while unequal lists give four distinct forced edges at the two degree-two states using the common colours. By exchanging coordinates suppose only A changes. If one value equals $B = \{a, b, c\}$, the common fibre is the path (ab, ac, bc, ba); its two end edges are forced in both cycles. Otherwise let a, b be the old and new excluded colours, c the fixed excluded colour and d the fourth colour. The common fibre has five vertices ca, cb, cd, da, db and six edges. The old outside states ba, bd occur consecutively because bd has degree two with neighbours ba, cd. Thus the old cycle uses exactly four common-fibre edges; the new cycle does likewise with ab, ad, cd. The cycles share at least $4 + 4 - 6 = 2$ edges.

Since $x \neq y$, a base step changes at most one list. Cut an edge of a base Hamilton cycle and process its fibres in path order. At each splice the current fibre has lost at most one edge and the next is fresh, so a common edge remains. Cutting its two copies and adding the two actual base-step edges merges the circles. The fibres partition all states, giving a spanning cycle. □

5.1 Two degree-two reductions

Lemma 5.6 (Separated degree-two vertices)**.** *Let G be planar of girth at least five and let u, v be nonadjacent vertices of degree two with $N(u) \cap N(v) = \varnothing$. If $H = G - \{u, v\}$ has Hamiltonian $\mathcal{R}_4(H)$, then $\mathcal{R}_4(G)$ is Hamiltonian.*

Proof. Set $S = \{u, v\}$. Every vertex of H has at most one neighbour in S. Let x, y be the neighbours of u; they are distinct and nonadjacent. The planar triangle-free graph $H - \{x, y\}$ admits a proper three-colouring by Grötzsch's theorem [6] (the empty graph has its empty colouring). Use colours $0, 1, 2$ there and give both x, y colour 3. This is a proper colouring of H leaving three colours available at u. The hypotheses of Lemma 3.5 hold with $k = 4$ and $|S| = 2$, so that lemma supplies the required Hamilton cycle. □

5.2 Restoring a $(2, 3, 2)$ path

The following reduction uses only a Hamilton cycle of the deleted graph. It processes an entire constant-boundary run together with its two neighbouring nonconstant fibres, retaining the edges needed for the next splice. The three external neighbours remain distinct actual vertices.

Proposition 5.7. *If $F = \mathcal{R}_3(P_3)$, then $F \,\square\, P_\ell$ is Hamiltonian for every $\ell \geq 2$.*

Proof. Partition F into its three centre-colour squares Q_b. Order each square as (q_0, q_1, q_2, q_3), where q_0, q_2 are its monochromatic-endpoint vertices. On $Q_b \square P_2$ use

$$(0, q_0), (1, q_0), (1, q_1), (0, q_1), (0, q_2), (1, q_2), (1, q_3), (0, q_3).$$

This cube cycle contains all four edges between layers 0 and 1. For larger ℓ, append each subsequent square by an ordinary edge splice using an internal edge of the newest layer. The initial newest layer has two internal edges; each appended layer retains three. This leaves all four original interlayer edges intact.

The three centre-colour squares of F are connected by three edges between monochromatic-endpoint vertices, one for each pair of centre colours. Choose a tree of two of these edges. Each chosen edge xy produces a square with vertices $(0, x), (1, x), (1, y), (0, y)$. Delete its two interlayer edges and add its two copies of xy, joining the corresponding strip cycles. The two selected interlayer edges at the middle strip are distinct. Two such splices give a single spanning cycle, for arbitrary $\ell \geq 2$. □

Let x, y, z be a path of degrees $2, 3, 2$. Its external neighbours, in that order, are p, q, r. Assume they are distinct and outside the path. For a bottom colouring with boundary $t = (f(p), f(q), f(r))$, write

$$B_t = \{(u, v, w) : u \neq v,\ v \neq w,\ u \neq t_0,\ v \neq t_1,\ w \neq t_2\}, \qquad u, v, w \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\}.$$

A boundary is *bad* if all three entries agree, and *good* otherwise. Up to colour permutations and path reversal the good types are $001, 010, 012$. Their orders are $6 + 4 + 4 = 14$, $9 + 4 + 4 = 17$, and $6 + 6 + 4 = 16$, respectively. The bad type 000 has order 12.

5.3 Good cycles with safe connecting edges

The cycles D_E, D_M, D_A for the normalized boundaries $001, 010, 012$ are specified by literal cycles and capacity checks in the companion certificate; the coordinates are uvw. Allow all their colour images and path reversals. Legality, cyclic adjacency, distinctness, and the counts above verify that each is a Hamilton cycle of its fibre.

For a bad boundary aaa, partition B_{aaa} into squares Q_c indexed by $c \neq a$, with fixed middle coordinate c. A good neighbour of aaa is obtained by changing position j from a to $b \neq a$. If j is an end position, then for each $c \notin \{a, b\}$ there is exactly one edge common to the good fibre and Q_c. Let P_t consist of these two edges. For middle-change or all-distinct boundaries set $P_t = \varnothing$. A good-cycle edge outside P_t is called *safe*. Directly from the supplementary path certificate, every allowed cycle has the following properties:

1. For an end change, it contains the unique edge in each Q_c, $c \notin \{a, b\}$, and two opposite edges of Q_b.

2. For a middle change it has no vertex in Q_b and contains three edges of each of the other two squares.

For $t = 001$, the two special edges are 123–323 and 132–232; the two edges in Q_1 are 313–213 and 212–312. For $t = 010$, the retained three-edge paths are $121, 321, 323, 123$ and $132, 232, 231, 131$. These descriptions also prove the assertions for every symmetry image.

Lemma 5.8 (Safe common edges)**.** *For adjacent good boundaries t, s, every allowed cycle at t and every allowed cycle at s have at least two common edges outside $P_t \cup P_s$.*

Proof. Partition the common fibre graph into its fixed-middle layers H_v and the edge set H_* changing the middle coordinate. In any block, if m edges remain outside $P_t \cup P_s$ and the two cycles retain x, y of them, they share at least $\max(0, x + y - m)$ safe edges. These bounds add over disjoint blocks. The supplementary path-kernel certificate classifies all allowed transitions and gives sufficient block counts for seven families, each yielding at least two.

Let a, b, c, d be distinct and use the selected cycles defined there. For $aab \to bab$, the common middle-b prism has no special edges. The E cycle retains one edge in each row triangle and two vertical edges. The cycle M_0 contains both these triangle edges, and M_1 both these vertical edges, giving two safe common edges in either case.

For $aba \to cba$, H_a has nine edges. Both cycles omit *bab*–*bac* and *bab*–*bad*: the M layer isolates *bab*, while the A path starts *bab*, *dab*. They retain three and five edges in this seven-edge universe, giving one common edge. In H_c they retain three and two of four edges, giving another. Both special sets are empty. Colour permutations and reversal transport all arguments, proving the assertion for every allowed labelled pair. □

5.4 A bad block with prescribed safe edges left intact

Lemma 5.9 (Bad-block lifting)**.** *Consider consecutive fibres with boundaries*

$$t, \underbrace{aaa, \ldots, aaa}_{\ell \text{ times}}, s, \qquad \ell \geq 1,$$

where t, s are good and each differs from aaa in one coordinate. When $\ell = 1$ suppose $t \neq s$. Choose any allowed good cycles at the two ends, and reserve at most one safe edge in each. The layered graph on these fibres has a Hamilton cycle retaining both reserved edges. Only consecutive-layer matching edges are used.

Proof. Call a common edge with Q_c *available* if it belongs to the chosen good cycle and is not its reserved edge. An end-change good cycle has available edges in all three squares: the two singleton edges are special, hence cannot have been reserved, and at least one of its two Q_b edges remains. A middle-change good cycle has at least two available edges in each of its two supported squares.

First suppose $\ell = 1$. Let S_L, S_R be the sets of square colours supported by available edges of the two chosen good cycles. Then $|S_L|, |S_R| \geq 2$ and $S_L \cup S_R = [4] \setminus \{a\}$: the only exception could be two middle changes to the same colour, which would give $t = s$.

Choose a common square with different available edges on the two sides. If either change is at the middle, any $c \in S_L \cap S_R$ works, since that side offers at least two edges. If both changes are at ends, choose $c \notin \{a, b_L, b_R\}$, where b_L, b_R are their changed colours. Its two singleton edges are different: different ends give different coordinate directions, while changes at the same end have $b_L \neq b_R$ and give opposite square edges.

Start with the two good cycles and three bad squares. Attach the chosen square to both good cycles using these different edges, and attach each other square to a supporting good cycle. These four incidences form a tree. Cuts at a good cycle lie in different middle-colour squares, and the two bridge-square cuts are distinct. Along each tree edge delete the two selected internal edges and add the two matching edges. Each splice joins disjoint cycles into one; all reserved edges survive.

Now let $\ell \geq 2$. Each good end supports at least two squares, so choose an available left edge in Q_c and an available right edge in Q_d with $c \neq d$. Build the three square-strip cycles as in Proposition 5.7. The cube formula there permits either perfect matching of a square to be used in the first layer, by rotating its cyclic order; the last layer of a two-layer strip uses the other matching. Consequently its first layer can retain any specified square edge. For a two-layer strip the same is true at its last layer; our two requirements are on different strips and are independent.

If $\ell \geq 3$, a last-layer requirement is met by appending each new square with a splice edge different from the required edge. There are initially two choices and subsequently three in the current last layer, so this is always possible. The new last square retains all edges except the splice edge. First-layer horizontal edges and all four original vertical edges survive these extensions.

Join the three strips using the two vertical-edge switches in Proposition 5.7; these do not affect either required horizontal edge. Finally join the left and right good cycles to their selected strip edges by two ordinary edge splices. The result is one Hamilton cycle. The reserved edges were never cut. This proves the claim for every length, rather than just a bounded set of runs. □

5.5 The complete path-lifting induction

Lemma 5.10 ($(2,3,2)$-path lifting)**.** *Suppose the three external neighbours of a degree-$(2,3,2)$ path are distinct and outside it. If the reconfiguration graph of the deleted graph is Hamiltonian at four colours, then so is $\mathcal{R}_4(G)$.*

Proof. Fix an arbitrary bottom Hamilton cycle. There must be a good vertex on it. Otherwise every boundary is constant; consecutive constant triples can only be equal, as at most one coordinate changes. The external colour would therefore be fixed throughout the cycle. A global colour permutation of a proper colouring supplies another proper colouring with a different external colour, a contradiction to Hamilton coverage. Thus even the startup uses only Hamiltonicity.

Every good bottom vertex has at most one bad neighbour in the entire bottom reconfiguration graph: a two-colour boundary has exactly one possible coordinate change making it constant, and an all-distinct boundary has none. The full neighbouring colouring, if proper, is uniquely determined by that change. Hence no good vertex on the Hamilton cycle can lie between two bad vertices. In particular there is an edge joining two good vertices.

Cut such an edge. In the resulting bottom Hamilton path, group each maximal bad run together with its two neighbouring good vertices; make each remaining good vertex a singleton block. These blocks are disjoint and partition the path. A bad run has constant boundary, and its two neighbours are distinct. If the run has length one their boundaries are different: otherwise both neighbours are obtained from the intervening colouring by the same one-vertex recolouring and would be the same bottom vertex.

For each labelled good boundary fix one allowed cycle once and for all. Consecutive blocks meet at a good–good boundary transition. If the boundary changes, Lemma 5.8 provides two common safe edges. If it stays unchanged, the fixed cycles coincide and have at least $14 - 2$ safe edges. Select one connecting edge for each interblock interface in path order. If a singleton block already has an incoming selected edge, choose a different outgoing one, which is possible from the two candidates. In a nonsingleton block the two selected edges are in its distinct end fibres, so cannot conflict.

Use Lemma 5.9 to construct each nonsingleton block cycle preserving its selected end edges; singleton blocks already have their fixed cycles. Splice the resulting disjoint block cycles along the selected interfaces. Each step joins two cycles into one, and every later selected edge is still present. The one-block case needs no final splice. All transitions are legal: a local step changes one path vertex, and a matching cross-edge performs its actual bottom recolouring while holding the local colouring fixed. Finally the fibres are disjoint and exhaust all proper colourings. Thus the resulting single cycle is Hamiltonian, including its closing edge. □

Theorem 5.11. *Let G be a nonempty finite simple planar graph of girth at least five and maximum degree at most three. Then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamiltonian for every $k \geq 4$. Disconnected graphs are allowed. The uniform Hamiltonian threshold of this class is exactly four; four-colour Hamilton-connectedness is not asserted.*

We prove a local restoration lemma using only Hamiltonicity of the smaller recolouring graph, and then supply the planar structure. The protected-pentagon step is a finite local kernel lemma. The companion certificate records cover the 2304 labelled boundaries and the 313 canonical one-entry interfaces. Its replay scripts check the literal cycles, seeds, pools, and explicit interface records; the article states the invariant needed for the arbitrary-order induction. The unrestricted planar girth-five four-colour question remains open.

5.6 The finite protected-edge identities

Put $Q = \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$. A boundary t has five entries in Q, with at most one entry $*$. Its local graph F_t consists of the proper C_5 colourings x satisfying $x_i \neq t_i$; $*$ excludes no colour. In the certificates $*$ is encoded by 4. The eleven ordinary types have 590 states in total. The constant type has two components, each a 15-cycle; all other ordinary types are connected. Eight have the printed Hamilton cycles, and the two remaining types are 00001 and 00112. With a full list, the eleven types, after rotation, reflection and colour permutation, are

$$0000*,\ 0001*,\ 0010*,\ 0011*,\ 0012*,\ 0101*,\ 0102*,\ 0110*,\ 0112*,\ 0120*,\ 0123*\,.$$

Their printed Hamilton cycles have respectively $54, 60, 78, 62, 71, 88, 85, 74, 74, 83, 82$ states, a total of 811. Thus there are 23 component types, including the two constant components.

Lemma 5.12 (Ordered path blocks)**.** *Every one of the 23 component types B has a partition into paths $P_1, \ldots, P_r$ of order two or three, with an actual B edge joining P_i to P_{i+1} for each $i < r$.*

Proof. Twenty-one types have the printed Hamilton cycles, and 00112 has the 51-state Hamilton path in the supplementary pentagon-kernel certificate. Delete a cycle edge where necessary, and divide the resulting path into consecutive two-vertex blocks, with one three-vertex block if its order is odd. For 00001, the supplementary certificate supplies the ordered path blocks and their actual connectors. The verifier checks coverage and every one-coordinate difference. □

For a Hamilton component A with specified cycle C_A, designate an ordered pool of five edges for either constant component, and eight edges otherwise. Let K_A be the other cycle edges. The first two pool edges join copies of C_A in a two- or three-row path product; the remaining edges supply at least two splice reserves. For a hard component, specify cycles of $A\square P_2$ and $A\square P_3$, and a set D_A of internal edges occurring in *every* row of both seeds. For each of 00001 and 00112, the companion certificate specifies a two-row cycle and derives its three-row seed by the same three-path insertion rule. Both use $|D_A| = 13$ and a two-edge pool. Put $K_A = D_A \setminus \text{pool}$; the two distinct pool edges supply the splice reserves.

Here is the exact normalization convention. Enumerate $s = 0, \ldots, 4$, then $\epsilon = +1, -1$, then the permutations $p \in S_4$ in lexicographic order. Take the first standard type $n_i = p(t_{s+\epsilon i})$, retaining $*$. Restoration puts the standard entry x_i at position $s + \epsilon i$ with colour $p^{-1}(x_i)$. In particular a standard boundary first normalizes by the identity.

Lemma 5.13 (Protected-edge identities)**.** *Let the source be a standard component A of F_t, and change one non-star boundary entry. Normalize the target by the preceding rule. Every target component B whose restored state set meets A has an edge in common with K_A after restoration of K_B. For an unchanged boundary use the same component and the same map.*

Proof. The ordinary and starred orbit representatives cover $4^5 + 5 \cdot 4^4 = 2304$ labelled boundaries. The displayed cyclic words give their specified component cycles and the two-row hard seeds:

their entries are precisely the legal words, without repetition, and successive entries, including last and first, differ in one coordinate. Both three-row seeds follow from the companion certificate's three-path insertion rule, using two edges and the displayed 40-state or 47-state path. Every listed common edge occurs in every row of both corresponding seeds. Removing the listed pools therefore defines the asserted protected sets. For the 313 standard-source interfaces, the companion certificate gives 47 individual common edges, twenty-one source-selector rows covering 236 cases, and six constant-source families covering 30 cases. Endpoint membership in the specified templates and outside their pools proves each individual record. The selector rows use fixed protected incident edges against the opposite component's full degree, with the prescribed first normalizer and pools. The constant-source families use two normalizing directions and four protected target edges. Inverse coordinate and colour maps give every labelled case. This is a complete finite case proof; no finite-length gluing experiment infers a general rule. □

5.7 Products retaining protection in every row

Lemma 5.14. *For any two of the 23 component types A, B, the graph $A\square B$ has a Hamilton cycle retaining a copy of every edge of K_A in every physical B row.*

Proof. Use the ordered path blocks of Lemma 5.12 for B. On each block construct its product cycle with A. If A has its specified cycle C_A, join two copies using the first pool edge; for a three-row block use the first and second pool edges at its two interfaces. These cuts are distinct in the middle row. If A is hard, use its specified two- or three-row seed. Every initial cycle retains K_A and at least two common reserve edges in every physical row.

Choose two distinct reserve edges e, f. Join consecutive block cycles by cutting their two copies of e or f, alternating along the block chain, and adding the two cross edges supplied by the indicated actual edge of B. Each block participates in at most two joins. If both use the same physical row, they cut different edges; thus every required copy is still present. Processing the blocks in order merges their disjoint cycles into one, covers every row, and never cuts K_A. □

Lemma 5.15. *For a fixed star position, or no star, let two boundaries be equal or differ in one non-star position. Any overlapping component pair has at least ten common vertices.*

Proof. An unchanged constant component has 15 vertices. Between a constant and nonconstant boundary, one additional colour is excluded at one coordinate of that 15-cycle. A cyclic permutation of its three colours preserves each component: an order-three action on a two-element component set is trivial. Hence each colour appears five times at each coordinate and precisely ten states remain. In every other case, both components are their entire local state sets. The intersection lists have size at least three except possibly one list of size two. Start at that position, proceed around the cycle, and finally avoid the two already coloured neighbours. This gives at least $2 \cdot 2^3 \cdot 1 = 16$ colourings. With no changed position the bound only improves. Full lists cause no difficulty. □

Consequently, if each of two boundaries changes at most one entry, normalize the target *relative to the source maps*. The two reference product cycles have at least ten common internal edges: one left protected edge from Lemma 5.13, copied at the ten or more common right states from Lemma 5.15. The two coordinate permutations and colour permutations may be independent. Actual synchronous changes are included in this stronger local classification; physical exterior vertices are never identified merely because they have equal colours.

5.8 An arbitrary bottom cycle

Lemma 5.16. *Suppose G has girth at least five and contains two vertex-disjoint 5-cycles with no edge between them. Each cycle has vertices of degree three except for at most one vertex of degree two. Let H be obtained by deleting both cycles. If $\mathcal{R}_4(H)$ is Hamiltonian, so is $\mathcal{R}_4(G)$. Neither planarity nor three-colourability of H is assumed here.*

Proof. Each degree-three cycle vertex has one exterior neighbour; a degree-two vertex gives a full list. An exterior vertex meets a given 5-cycle at most once, since two attachments would create a 3- or 4-cycle. Thus a bottom recolouring changes at most one list in each factor. The two factors may change simultaneously. All exterior neighbours remain in H, which is nonempty.

Along a bottom Hamilton cycle, every ordinary pentagon has a nonconstant boundary somewhere. Otherwise consecutive constant five-tuples, differing in at most one entry, must be equal. Its entire boundary would stay fixed along the bottom cycle. A global colour permutation changing that colour supplies another proper colouring of H which the Hamilton cycle must visit, a contradiction. These nonconstant layers need not coincide for the two factors.

Make a component graph whose vertices are all product components in all bottom layers, joining components in consecutive layers when they have a common local state. There are at most four components per layer and every component-graph degree is at most eight. This graph is connected. Indeed, on each constant run the two 15-cycle components can be labelled consistently by a binary bit: consecutive constant boundaries are equal. A nonconstant layer forgets, or resets, that bit. A starred factor resets it at every layer. Take four bit-labelled copies of the bottom cycle and allow a flip of each bit at its reset layers. This graph is connected because each bit has a reset somewhere. Contract the reset edges within each layer. The result is exactly the component graph: intersections between nonconstant components are nonempty, each constant component meets its nonconstant neighbour, and an unchanged constant component meets precisely itself.

Choose a spanning tree of the component graph. Give the root one product cycle from Lemma 5.14 and record its two restoration maps. For a child, apply the inverse parent maps to the target boundaries, normalize, then compose restoration maps. The target component is fixed by any common state. This makes the source a standard type for the protected-edge table, so the two *reference* product cycles share at least ten internal edges. The parent's component has tree degree at most eight and has so far lost at most seven internal edges. The child is fresh. Choose an unused common edge xy, delete its two copies and add the cross-layer edges at x and y. Each cross edge is the actual bottom recolouring with the complete local colouring unchanged. The two circles become two paths joined into one circle. Induction over the tree preserves one circle, disjoint coverage and legality, and ends with all extensions of all bottom colourings. There is no additional unproved closing step. □

5.9 The planar structural reduction

Lemma 5.17. *Every connected plane graph of girth at least five with $2 \le d(v) \le 3$ and at most one degree-two vertex contains two vertex-disjoint 5-cycles with no edge between them.*

Proof. For any connected cyclic plane graph of girth at least five and maximum degree three, let p and q count vertices of degrees one and two. Euler's identity, $2e = 3n - 2p - q$, and the face-length sum give

$$f_5 = 12 - 4p - 2q + \sum_{|F|\ge 7} (|F| - 6). \qquad (*)$$

Every facial walk contains a cycle and so has length at least five; bridges count twice. A length-five facial walk is a simple 5-cycle. For the graph in the lemma, $p = 0, q \le 1$, hence $f_5 \ge 12 - 2q$.

If there is a bridge ab, take the side C not containing the unique degree-two vertex, if it exists. In C, only a has degree two and all other vertices have degree three. This side is cyclic, and (*) gives at least ten 5-faces. At most two contain a. Choose a 5-cycle S avoiding a. The other bridge side has either at most two degree-two vertices, or one degree-one vertex when b was the original degree-two vertex. All other vertices have degree three. The degree sum rules out a tree and (*) gives at least eight 5-faces. Any such cycle P is disjoint from S and has no edge to it, because ab was the only edge between the sides.

Assume now there is no bridge. The subcubic graph is 2-connected: at a cutvertex every branch would require at least two incident edges to avoid a bridge, forcing degree at least four. Take a facial 5-cycle S and let B be its exterior neighbours. Girth makes them distinct; $b = |B|$ is five, or four when S contains the unique degree-two vertex z. Set $H = G - S$, embedded with the deleted region outside. Every member of B is on that outside face. Its degree drops from three to two, except that $z \in B$ would become a leaf. There is at most one leaf and no isolated vertex, so every component of H is cyclic.

In one such component, let r count its members of B, $q' \leq 1$ its original degree-two vertices, and ℓ its outside facial length. Formula (*) after removing the outside-face contribution is

$$f_5^{\text{in}} = \ell + 6 - 2r - 2q' + L, \qquad L = \sum_{\substack{F \text{ internal} \\ |F| \geq 7}} (|F| - 6) \geq 0. \tag{**}$$

Even when $z \in B$, the degree deficit $4p + 2q$ remains $2r + 2q'$, so the formula still applies. Here $\ell \geq 5$. A member of B belongs to at most one internal 5-face: its degree is at most two, with an outside face angle, and a leaf belongs to none. If H is disconnected, some component has $r \leq 2$ since $|B| \leq 5$. By (**) it has at least $9 - 2r > r$ internal 5-faces. One avoids B, and is the required P.

Suppose H is connected. The b exterior edges partition the outside angles along S into b face portions, so at most b other faces are involved. Deleting five vertices and $5 + b$ edges decreases the face count by b; thus these b neighbours $F_1, \ldots, F_b$ are distinct. Their merger has outside length

$$\ell = \sum_{i=1}^{b} |F_i| - (2b + 5), \tag{***}$$

because the five cycle edges are removed once and the b outgoing edges twice from that sum.

If $q = 0$, any S has $b = 5$, $\ell \geq 10$, $q' = 0$. Formula (**) gives at least six internal 5-faces, more than $|B|$. If z lies on a 5-face, choose that face as S. Now $b = 4$, $\ell \geq 7$, $q' = 0$, and there are at least five, again more than $|B|$.

It remains that z lies on no 5-face. There is a 5-face adjacent to two distinct non-5-faces. To see this, consider the plane dual. It is loopless because the original graph is bridgeless. All its faces are triangles except one digon corresponding to z. The distinct endpoints of that digon both represent non-5-faces. Let W be the set of all such dual vertices. If every vertex outside W had at most one distinct neighbour in W, a triangular face incident with a W–W edge would have its third vertex in W. Starting with a digon edge and going around either endpoint therefore shows that all its neighbours are in W: a triangular face propagates the property to the next neighbour, and the digon merely repeats the same neighbour. Repeating at any reached neighbour makes W closed under adjacency. Dual connectivity would force all vertices into W, contradicting $f_5 \geq 10$. This proves the assertion. Choose the resulting 5-face S. If its deletion disconnects the graph, use the case already proved; otherwise $b = 5, q' = 1$ and two distinct neighbours in (***) have length at least six. Thus $\ell \geq 12$ and (**) again gives at least six internal 5-faces. In every case one avoids B, making it disjoint and nonadjacent to S. □

5.10 Induction, checks and the remaining frontier

Proof of Theorem 5.11. Induct on the number of vertices, allowing disconnected graphs. The one-vertex case is $\mathcal{R}_4(G) = K_4$. A vertex of degree at most one is handled by Lemma 2.2. If there are two degree-two vertices, adjacent ones use Lemma 5.5. Ones at distance two use Lemma 5.10, unless their middle vertex has degree two, when an adjacent pair already applies. Ones at distance at least three use Lemma 5.6, whose spare-colour witness uses Grötzsch's theorem [6]; the new pentagon lift does not. Pairs in different components have disjoint neighbourhoods and are covered by the same separated-pair argument.

The remaining graph has minimum degree at least two and at most one degree-two vertex. Apply Lemma 5.17 inside any component. Delete its two separated pentagons. The remaining graph is nonempty and belongs to the same class, so induction gives its four-colour Hamilton cycle. Lemma 5.16 restores both pentagons. This proves the assertion at four colours. For every $k \geq 5$ use the triangle-free planar theorem proved earlier, with larger colours separately supplied there by degeneracy. The frozen 012012 colouring of C_6 gives the Hamiltonian threshold lower bound four. No monotonicity in k is presumed. □

5.11 Block-subcubic lemma

Lemma 5.18. *Let G be a nonempty finite simple planar graph of girth at least five. If every block B satisfies $\Delta(B) \leq 3$, then $\mathcal{R}_k(G)$ is Hamiltonian for every $k \geq 4$. Cutvertices may have arbitrarily large degree in G. The uniform Hamiltonian threshold of this class is exactly four. Four-colour Hamilton-connectedness is not asserted.*

Proof. Treat bridges as two-vertex blocks and isolated vertices as singleton blocks. The class is closed under vertex deletion: a nontrivial two-connected block of a subgraph is a two-connected subgraph of G, hence is contained in one original block, with no larger internal degrees. Planarity and girth are also preserved.

Products of Hamiltonian graphs are Hamiltonian: copy one factor cycle along a spanning path of another factor cycle, and merge successive copies using two alternating, distinct internal edges. This also handles disconnected original graphs. Choose a smallest four-colour counterexample, which may therefore be assumed connected. The singleton base is K_4, and the single-vertex lift excludes vertices of degree at most one. If there is only one block, the previous subcubic girth-five theorem applies. Thus assume minimum degree at least two and at least one cutvertex.

Lemmas 5.5, 5.10, and 5.6 exclude adjacent degree-two vertices, a $(2, 3, 2)$ path, and two degree-two vertices at distance at least three. Consequently any two degree-two vertices not already giving a reduction must have a common neighbour of degree at least four in G.

The block-cut tree has at least two endblocks. No endblock is a bridge, since its noncut endpoint would be a leaf. Let B be an endblock and x its unique cutvertex of G. Every vertex of $B - x$ has its full G-degree in B, hence degree two or three; also $d_B(x) \in \{2, 3\}$. Let q count the degree-two vertices of $B - x$ and put $\varepsilon = [d_B(x) = 2]$. If $q \geq 2$, any pair of these vertices has a common neighbour of G-degree at least four by the excluded reductions. Their neighbours all lie in B, so only x can be this common neighbour. Every one of the q vertices is therefore adjacent to x, giving $q \leq d_B(x) = 3 - \varepsilon$. Together with the immediate $q \leq 1$ case, this proves $q + \varepsilon \leq 3$.

Euler's identity in the two-connected block B now gives

$$f_5(B) = 12 - 2(q + \varepsilon) + \sum_{|F| \geq 7} (|F| - 6) \geq 6.$$

Each five-face is a simple pentagon, while at most $d_B(x) \leq 3$ faces meet x, so choose one avoiding x. If $q \leq 1$, it contains at most one degree-two vertex of G. If $q \geq 2$, a cycle through any of the q

vertices must use its edge to x, so the chosen pentagon contains none. All its other vertices have G-degree three.

Choose these pentagons in two distinct endblocks. Their vertices are noncutvertices of G and belong to their respective endblocks only, so the pentagons are disjoint and have no edge between them. The established protected-edge lift for two separated pentagons applies, including its allowance of one degree-two vertex per pentagon and simultaneous exterior list changes. The smaller graph remains in the class and has a bottom Hamilton cycle by induction. Restoration contradicts minimality.

For every $k \geq 5$ separately use the established triangle-free planar theorem. Finally C_6 belongs to the class and its periodic 012012 colouring is frozen in $\mathcal{R}_3(C_6)$, giving the lower bound four. No monotonicity in the number of colours has been assumed. □

In particular, a remaining minimum counterexample for general planar girth-five four-colour Hamiltonicity must contain a block with a vertex of degree at least four *inside that block*. High total degree accumulated only at cutvertices is insufficient. This does not assert that every minimum counterexample is two-connected.

6 Sharpness and the unresolved frontier

The lower bounds used above are frozen colourings, not claims about a particular embedding.

Proposition 6.1 (Sharpness examples)**.** *The following obstructions hold.*

(i) The icosahedral graph has a frozen proper six-colouring (see Bousquet–Perarnau [3]), so $\mathcal{R}_6$ is disconnected. Hence the planar threshold is at least seven.

(ii) The cube has a frozen proper four-colouring (identify colours with $\mathbb{Z}_2^2$ and use the three nonzero edge directions), so triangle-free and bipartite planar classes have threshold at least five.

(iii) A cycle whose length is a multiple of three has a frozen periodic three-colouring. This gives the lower bound four for girth at least six and for the four-colour girth-five subclasses containing C_6.

(iv) $\mathcal{R}_3(P_3)$ at $k = 3$ has twelve states; its six degree-two states force three disjoint four-cycles, so it has no spanning cycle. Thus the forest threshold cannot be three.

Proof. For (i)–(iii), every vertex sees all colours other than its own, so the displayed colouring is frozen. For (iv), the forced-edge description of $\mathcal{R}_3(P_3)$ gives three disjoint four-cycles. □ □

The general planar girth-five problem is deliberately left at the following boundary:

$$4 \leq h(\mathcal{P}_5) \leq 5, \qquad 4 \leq \mathrm{hc}(\mathcal{P}_5) \leq 5,$$

where $\mathcal{P}_5$ is the class of planar graphs of girth at least five. The upper bounds are the five-colour Hamilton-connected theorem. The lower bounds record the four-colour boundary; no complete-state-graph counterexample has been verified in the present record.

The following implications are invalid and are not used here:

- a connected or 2-connected recolouring graph need not have a Hamilton cycle;
- a Hamilton cycle in a fixed list fibre need not extend to the complete recolouring graph;

- a spanning two-factor, a quotient cycle, or a finite local kernel does not by itself give a single Hamilton cycle;
- the four-colour result for at most seven five-cycles or for subcubic graphs does not settle all planar graphs of girth at least five.

7 Threshold summary

Class	h	hc
All planar graphs	7	7
Triangle-free planar graphs	5	5
Planar girth at least six	4	4
Nonempty forests	4	4
Planar girth at least five, at most seven 5-cycles	4	$4 \le \mathrm{hc} \le 5$
Planar girth at least five, $\Delta \le 3$	4	$4 \le \mathrm{hc} \le 5$
General planar girth at least five	$4 \le h \le 5$	$4 \le \mathrm{hc} \le 5$

8 Verification note

The finite data used for the endpoint-sensitive statements were replayed in fresh output directories. The local Hamilton-connected kernel for the triangle-free five-colour induction consists of 53 representatives, 225 labelled list pairs, and 3225 legal interfaces; the independent reader checked 27,600 entry cases. These numbers certify the displayed finite local templates only. For the protected pentagon lift, the protected reader covered 23 component types, 2304 labelled boundaries, and 313 interface cases, with at least ten common states per interface. Six constant-source families cover 30 cases; twenty-one source-selector rows cover 236 by the fixed-side incident-degree criterion, leaving 47 individual edge records. The ordered path blocks in Lemma 5.12 use the existing component cycles, the 51-state path for 00112, and the 22-edge chain for 00001. The separate 40-state and 47-state paths generate both hard three-row seeds by the same three-path insertion rule, retaining thirteen common ports in every row. The 00112 protected set is unchanged; 00001 uses eleven protected edges with three repaired individual witnesses. The eleven-type factor-word enumeration is no longer a proof premise. The block-structure reader checked 22 structures, including a candidate whole graph with 1,495,752 states. These are bounded certificate replays, not arbitrary-size graph searches.

The companion certificate source distributed with this article retains the literal words, pools, interface records, and replay scripts. The compact article moves those finite words out of the narrative; it does not discard the evidence needed to check the local lemmas.

For $(2, 3, 2)$-path restoration, the three displayed cycles are used through fixed-middle-layer and middle-change-edge capacity bounds rather than an interface witness table.

All arbitrary-order assertions in this paper are supplied by the analytic inductions: the degenerate theorem, the separated-degree arguments in the planar Hamilton-connected proofs, the Euler reductions for the few-five-cycle class, and the protected-edge restoration for the subcubic classes. The finite checks do not constitute external peer review, formal verification, or an extrapolation from sampled graphs. The current research record keeps the complete planar girth-five four-colour Hamiltonian and Hamilton-connected statements as unresolved.

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